

Sparks of Fire

A write-up on **Mysore** in early 1900s

Please read this event schedule.

Place: Mumbai

Date: A day in **1967** - probably June 3rd

Venue: Tata Institute of Social Sciences, **Mumbai**

Program: 27th Annual Convocation

Chief Guest: Swami Ranganathananda ji Maharaj (58 years of age) (Secretary, Ramakrishna Mission Institute of Culture, Kolkatta)

Chairman: Prof. A.R. Wadia (78 years of age) (he was called due to a last minute change in schedule of Sri Homi Modi) (Mr. Wadia was Director of TISS between 1953 to 1962)

Most of us do not see anything different! Right?

Actually, there is a beautiful story and a course of events behind this event.

About **45 years** prior to this event, both the Chief guest and the Chairman were in another city as student and teacher.

Prof A.R. Wadia was heading the dept of philosophy in Mysore University in early 1900s and Swami Ranganathananda Maharaj was his student - not in the college, but in the Mysore Ashrama!

Before we go further, please read this news item that appeared in **September 1932** issue of **Vedanta Kesari**.

News item that appeared in *Vedanta Kesari* September 1932 issue

A Study Centre at Mysore

It was the great desire of Swami Vivekananda to present Vedanta to the modern world from the standpoint of scientific thought. With this end in view the Sri Ramakrishna Ashrama in Mysore has started a Study Class. The object is to acquaint the Sannyasins of the Ramakrishna Mission with the scientific and philosophic knowledge of the West. Some of the professors of the Mysore University and Pandits of the Maharaja's Sanskrit College have kindly agreed to help the Sadhus in their studies and take classes in the Ashrama. The course of study includes Comparative Religion, Psychology and Philosophy of Religion, Logic, Scientific Method, Western Philosophy and Vedanta in all its phases. The classes began on the 16th of May with blessings from His Holiness **Swami Shivananda**, the President of the Ramakrishna Mission. The course is expected to last for about two years. The Ashrama cannot sufficiently thank His Highness, **the Maharaja of Mysore**, for the uniform sympathy evinced by him in matters relating to the activities of the Ashrama from its very inception. It is a source of the highest gratification to the Swamis that such institutions have grown under the spiritual auspices of an Indian ruler, so exceptionally good and godly.

The last words - "an Indian ruler, so exceptionally good and godly" - triggered a study of history of Mysore during 1900s. The following timeline is based on that study.

The ruler referred here is **His Highness Nalvadi Sri Krishnaraja Wodeyar-IV**.

Instead of writing a lengthy essay, this timeline format is made as a pointer and the readers can google on anything specific later. The focus here is on spirituality and philosophy only.

4th June 1884 – Birth of **Nalvadi Krishna Raja Wodeyar IV** in Mysore.

4th June 1888 – Birth of A. R. Wadia (Ardeshir Ruttonji Wadia) in Mumbai.

1892 - **Swami Vivekananda** visited Mysore at the invitation of the Dewan then – Seshadri Iyer in November 1892. Swamiji impressed the Dewan and the Maharaja Chamarajendra Wodeyar. Had several rounds of discussions with the Maharaja on the real wealth of Bhaarat and what Bhaarat needs. Stayed for 3 to 4 weeks in Mysore. Both Swamiji and the Maharaja were only 29 years old.

December 1894 – Maharaja Chamarajendra Wodeyar (Father of Krishna Raja Wodeyar IV) died (aged 31) during a visit to Calcutta.

1st February 1895 – Coronation - **Sri Nalvadi Krishna Raja Wodeyar IV** became successor to King of Mysore at age 11. His mother **Maharani Vani Vilas Sannidhana** became Regent until 1902. In 1902, after becoming major, he was officially King of Mysore princely state.

1897 – Gopal Marar (later **Swami Siddheswarananda**) was born in Kochi (Cochin) in Kerala.

15th December 1908 – Shankaran (later **Swami Ranganathananda**) was born in Thrikkur near Thrissur in Kerala. (Close to Kalady where Adi Sankara was born many centuries ago)

1916 - Department of Philosophy was started in University of Mysore. Dr. A.R. Wadia (Oxford educated) from Mumbai became Professor and head of department (1917 to 1942)

1917- **Swami Brahmananda** gives mantra deeksha to Gopal Maharaj (later Swami Siddheswarananda) in Madras.

1918 to 1921 – Prof **Sarvapalli Radhakrishnan** (later President of India) worked in the philosophy department

Sometime during 1900-1918 V. Subrahmania Iyer arrived in Mysore from Agra in North India. Worked in Education department of Mysore State as head master and in various

capacities. Became disciple/devotee of **Swami Narasimha Bharati of Sringeri Math** and learnt Advaita and Upanishads from him. Many of his annual vacations are spent in Sringeri Math in scriptural studies.

1919 – Sri Hiriyantha became Professor in Sanskrit department in Mysore University. M. V. Seetharamiah, P. T. Narasimhachar (**PuTiNa**), V. Seetharamaiah (**VeeSee**) were his students.

1920 – V. Subrahmanya Iyer became Registrar of Mysore University and also taught in Dept of Sanskrit. He became a Reader in Philosophy to the Maharaja later.

1921 – 1924 (**Swami Siddheswarananda** was a student of Sarvapalli Radhakrishnan in Presidency College, Madras)

1924 – **Swami Siddheswarananda** (Gopal Maharaj) was given sannyas (in Madras) by **Swami Shivananda** a direct disciple of Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa.

11th June 1925 – Ramakrishna Ashrama was established in Mysore by **Swami Siddheswarananda** (Gopal Maharaj). He hailed from the royal family of Kochi (Cochin). Right from his student days in Madras, he frequently visited Tiruvannamalai to have darshan of Sri Ramana Maharshi and had great respect for the Master.

(Year not available) K.V. Puttappa (later pen name - "**Kuvempu**") came to Mysore for secondary education and degree.

1926 – **Swami Ranganathananda Maharaj** (Shankar Maharaj) barely **17 years old**, arrived in Mysore and joined in Mysore Ramakrishna Mission Ashram. As soon as he reached Mysore on 2nd July 1926, he took care of the Ashram kitchen work. There was no paid cook since the Ashram income was very meager.

1929 – K.V. Puttappa ("**Kuvempu**") graduated majoring in Kannada from Maharaja's College Mysore University. Received initial training from Ramakrishna Ashrama and initiation from **Shivananda Maharaj** a direct disciple of Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa. Swami Siddheswarananda helped Kuvempu during these formative years.

1926 to 1933 – **Swami Yatiswarananda** was the head of Ramakrishna Math in Chennai. After that, Swami went to Germany and later to USA.

1929 – Swami Ranganathananda received brahmacharya vows on 23 March 1929 from **Swami Shivananda**

1932 – The Maharaja of Mysore provided a grant for a building and to start a study circle for monks of Ramakrishna order to study Vedanta as well as Western philosophy and Logic. Professors from Philosophy and Sanskrit departments of Mysore University taught

them. One of them was Dr. A.R.Wadia. Another was the registrar V.Subrahmania Iyer. Monks from other centers of Ramakrishna Mission also were benefitted. Paul Brunton (writer) also has attended some classes. Paul was close to Subrahmania Iyer until Iyer's death.

"The Mysore study circle was in a way the nucleus of the now well established Training Centre for the monastic probationers in Belur Math". - RKM Mysuru website

1933 – Swami Ranganathananda received sannyasa on 23 January 1933, from **Swami Shivananda**.

1933- Swami Ranganathananda ji had commenced addressing the prisoners on ethical and spiritual life in Mysore Jail in 1933-34, and this he continued in Bangalore, among the youth, where he moved in 1935.

1935 – Swami Siddheswarananda and Swami Ranganathananda were posted in Bangalore Ramakrishna Mission.

1935 – Dewan Sir Mirza Ismail visited an electric factory in Paris. Meets its GM - Maurice Frydman, a Jewish engineer from Poland and offered a position – Maurice came to Mysore state in 1935 to work in Bengaluru as Managing Director of Government Electric Factory.

1937 - On 28th February 1937, the Maharaja went to the ashram of **Sri Ramana Maharshi** in Tiruvannamalai and had a 15 minute darshan with Maharshi alone. Later when asked about the meeting, Ramana Maharshi said "**He is a ripe soul**".

1937 - Swami Siddheswarananda Maharaj left India to start a center in France.

1939 – Swami Ranganathananda was posted in Rangoon (Burma,) became the secretary and librarian of Ramakrishna Mission Rangoon.

1935 – 1939 Maurice visited Tiruvannamalai frequently to have darshan of Sri Ramana Maharshi. He collated important conversations with Maharshi into a book form "**Maharshi's Gospel**" in 1939. Took sannyas from Sri 'Papa' Ramadas in Anandashram Kerala with monastic name "Bharatananda".

3rd August 1940 – Maharaja Nalvadi Krishna Raja Wodeyar IV expired in Mysore. He was 56 years of age and completed 38 years of reign known as a **Golden Age** or **Ram Rajya** of **Mysore**.

1951 – Swami Yatiswarananda returned and became head of Bangalore Ashrama.

1953 to 1962 – Prof. A.R. Wadia worked as director of **Tata Institute of Social Sciences**

(TISS) in Mumbai.

1956 – Prof K.V. Puttappa (“**Kuvempu**”) became Vice Chancellor of Mysore University.

2nd April 1957 – Swami Siddheswarananda (aged 59) expired in Gretz, Paris. Until his death he corresponded with his teacher Dr. S. Radhakrishnan frequently.

1939 to 1971 -

Maurice helped in the re-settlement of Tibetan Refugees between 1950 to 1967. While many states were hesitating Karnataka (post independence) provided settlement area in Bylakuppe near Mysore. Possibly Maurice was helped by old friends in Mysore/Bangalore.

Later Maurice would become close to Nisargadatta Maharaj (Advaita Master of Inchgiri sampradaya) in Mumbai and publish the book “**Who am I**”. Maurice himself transcribed and translated from Marathi to English and this book is very popular even now. Normally English is very difficult to express subtle ideas about the mind and spirit.

The book is a good example for written English used to express such difficult ideas in simple English. Maurice was a polyglot and knew English, Polish, Russian, French, Kannada, Tamil, Marathi, and Hindi.

1967 – Swami Ranganathananda (now aged 58) is the chief guest of convocation at TISS and Prof Wadia (age 78) is the Chairman of Convocation (due to last minute change in schedule).

3rd June 1967

As chairman of convocation Prof. Wadia mentioned these lines in his “Chairman’s address”:

"But I am really happy that for the first time this rule has been broken and we find a saffron robed gentleman delivering the Convocation Address this year. This is the second new feature of this Convocation. There is a fitness in this because through centuries of Indian history, the saffron colour has represented the spirit of self-sacrifice, a spirit of service, giving up worldly ambitions and leading a life of poverty and chastity devoted to the well-being of Indian citizens at large. It is in the fitness of things that Swamiji should have been honoured by this invitation and I am particularly grateful to him for having accepted this invitation".

...

I particularly remember the devotion with which he served Swami Siddheswarananda.

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It happened that my very good friend, the late Subrahmanya Iyer, Registrar of the University of Mysore, and a very keen student of Advaita philosophy, had a great deal of influence with the late His Highness the Maharaja of Mysore who was persuaded to give money for the starting of classes for the members of the **Ramakrishna Mission Ashram** not merely in Mysore but in the whole world so that they could hear and study Ramakrishna's and

Swami Vivekananda's teachings of ancient Indian philosophy and also study modern philosophy, modern sociology and modern ethics so as to give them an up-to-date colour. These classes were started and many of us in the University of Mysore gave lectures and Swamiji (Ranganathananda) was one of the earliest students of this study centre. I need hardly say that all of them were very earnest in their work and devoted to scholarship. This act of His Highness yielded very high dividends. Swami Siddheswarananda himself was selected to be sent to Paris for starting a Vedantic Centre there which he did with great success. I remember meeting him in Paris in 1952 and I enjoyed his hospitality and we continued to be very good friends but he died much too early, barely four years after my last contact. But till the last we had lengthy correspondence.

21st August 1971 – Prof A.R. Wadia aged 83 expired in Mumbai.

25th April, 2005

Swami Ranganathananda expired in Kolkatta. He was 96 years of age.

Quote from V.Subrahmanya Iyer on the Maharaja of Mysore:-

“During the past fourteen years I have had the valuable privilege of being a Reader in Philosophy to **His Highness Sri Krishnaraja Wodeyar Bahadur IV**, Maharaja of Mysore, a ruler of remarkable metaphysical insight and attainments, who has been referred to, in contemporary literature, as a modern “example of Plato’s conception of the Philosopher-King.”

The Timeline ends here.

If we look at the events in the right perspective , the course of events will appear like an interesting drama scripted in real life by the grace of the Masters.

Poet Bharathiyar -

I found a young spark of fire ,
I kept it in a cavity of a tree in a forest yonder,
The entire forest got burned down!
The entire forest got burned down!
In fiery bravery, is there youth and old age?

Swami Vivekananda has found many such young sparks of fire. He continues to find them. The forests of ignorance will continue to get burned down.

Guru Maharaj ki Jai!

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